Case Study: The "Electricity Bill" Phishing Scam

1. The Incident

A well-educated individual (referred to as Victim V) received an urgent SMS claiming to be from the State Electricity Board (MSEB). The message stated that their electricity connection would be disconnected by 9:30 PM that night because the previous month's bill remained unpaid. It provided a "helpline number" to resolve the issue immediately.

2. The Modus Operandi

- **The Hook:** Fear and urgency. The threat of losing power at night forced the victim to act quickly without verifying the claim.
- **The Interaction:** When the victim called the number, the "executive" (the scammer) spoke professionally and confirmed the "pending bill." They asked the victim to download a small support app (like AnyDesk or TeamViewer) to help update the payment status in the system.
- **The Trap:** Once the app was installed, the scammer could see the victim's phone screen in real-time. They asked the victim to make a "test payment" of just **₹1** via their UPI app to "reactivate" the account.
- **The Theft:** As the victim entered their **UPI PIN**, the scammer saw the PIN through the screen-sharing app. Within minutes, the scammer used this PIN to initiate several unauthorized transactions, emptying the victim's linked bank accounts of over **₹18,000**.

3. The Outcome

The victim immediately contacted their bank and the cybercrime helpline (1930). However, because the victim had technically "authorized" the transactions (by entering the PIN on their own device), the bank initially refused a refund, citing a "voluntary share of credentials."

Analysis of Common UPI Frauds

Fraud Type	How it Works
Screen Sharing	Scammers trick you into downloading apps that let them see your screen, allowing them to steal your PIN as you type it.
Collect Request	You receive a notification to "Receive Money" or "Claim Cashback." In reality, it is a **Request Money** prompt. If you enter your PIN, money is *debited* from your account.
QR Code Scam	A scammer sends a QR code claiming you need to scan it to *receive* money. **Remember:** Scanning a QR and entering a PIN is *only* for sending money.
SIM Swap	Fraudsters convince the mobile operator to issue a new SIM card for your number. They then receive your OTPs and take over your UPI-linked accounts.

Lessons & Prevention

- **PIN = Outgoing Money:** You **never** need to enter your UPI PIN to receive money. If a "refund" or "prize" asks for your PIN, it is a scam.
- **Avoid Remote Apps:** Never download screen-sharing apps on the instructions of a stranger, even if they claim to be from a bank or government office.
- **Check the Name:** Before hitting 'Proceed' on any UPI app, look at the **Verified Merchant Name** that appears. Scammers often use names like "Electricity_Dept_Official" which are not legitimate.
- **The 1930 Helpline:** If you are a victim of fraud, the first 1-2 hours (the "Golden Hour") are critical. Calling **1930** or reporting on **cybercrime.gov.in** immediately can help freeze the money in the scammer's account before they withdraw it.